

FREE GUIDE

The Small Shop Playbook

Practical ways to stop losing money, run a calmer day and keep your bays full.

For independent auto repair shops with ten technicians or fewer.

XSite Auto xsiteauto.com

BEFORE YOU START

You didn't open a shop to do paperwork.

Most owners of small shops are the best technician in the building, the service writer, the parts runner and the bookkeeper, all at once. The work in the bays is rarely the problem. The money and the hours leak out around it: the call that went to voicemail, the half hour of labour nobody wrote down, the balance that was going to be paid Friday.

This playbook is a collection of habits that well-run small shops use to plug those leaks. None of it needs new software. Every idea works with a paper schedule and a clipboard. Where a tool helps, we say so, and we point out how XSite Auto handles it, but the habits come first.

> **Pick one fix a week. In a month you'll have a calmer shop. In three months you'll see it in the bank account.**

PART 1 — **Ten places small shops lose money**
The everyday leaks, and a simple fix for each one.

PART 2 — **Running the day, from first call to close**
A routine for the counter, the bays and the cash drawer.

PART 3 — **Keeping the schedule full**
How customers find you, book you and come back.

LAST — **Your first 30 days**
A week-by-week checklist to put it all into practice.

This guide was written alongside a working independent repair shop in Niagara, Ontario, run by a former Toyota master technician. The habits in it come from his counter and his bays.

PART 1

Ten places small shops lose money

None of these will show up as a line on your profit and loss statement. They show up as a busy month that somehow didn't pay much. Go through the list and be honest about which ones sound familiar.

1 Missed calls

When you're under a car, the phone rings out. A new customer rarely leaves a message. They call the next shop on the list, and that job, plus every job after it, is gone.

The fix

- For one week, write down every call you couldn't answer. Most owners are surprised by the number.
- Return every missed call within 15 minutes, or have one person whose job is the phone during your busiest hours.
- Give customers a way to book without calling at all. Change your voicemail to say where they can book online.

> **In XSite Auto:** customers book from your website or booking page any time of day, and each request lands on your schedule.

2 Labour that never makes it onto the invoice

"While it's in" work adds up: topping up fluids, re-seating a connector, a quick look at a noise. Each is a few minutes. Across a week it can be hours of a technician's time given away.

The fix

- Write every task on the repair order, even when you decide to charge nothing. You can't decide to give work away if you never saw it.
- At close, read through the day's repair orders and ask the technicians what they did that isn't on them.

3 Free diagnosis

Diagnosis is skilled work. When it's free, customers shop the quote around and the next shop does the repair with your findings.

The fix

- Post a diagnostic fee at the counter and say it on the phone. Many shops credit it toward the repair if the customer goes ahead.
- Time-box diagnosis. If it runs past the first block, call the customer before continuing.

4 Jobs stuck waiting for approval

A car sits on a hoist while the service writer plays phone tag with the owner. The bay is blocked, the technician is waiting, and the day slips.

The fix

- Ask every customer at drop-off how they want to be reached and whether you can go ahead on anything under a set amount.
- Send the quote by text or email with a photo, not only a voicemail. Record who approved, what amount, and when.
- Make one person responsible for chasing approvals, with a check twice a day.

> **In XSite Auto:** the shop board has its own "waiting on approval" column, so stuck cars are visible at a glance.

5 Parts priced on the fly

When markup is decided at the counter, it drifts. Some parts go out at cost, returns don't get credited, and cores sit in the corner instead of going back.

The fix

- Write down a simple parts pricing guide by cost range and stick to it.
- Once a week, match supplier invoices against repair orders. Every part bought should be on a job or on a return.
- Keep a core and return log with a date and a credit amount.

6 Comebacks

A comeback costs twice: the free labour to fix it, and the bay it takes from a paying job. It also costs trust.

The fix

- Use a short road-test and final check list on every job, signed by the technician.
- Have a second person check brakes, steering and wheels after the work is done.
- Keep a simple comeback log by job type and technician. Patterns show up within a month.

7 Balances that slip through the cracks

"I'll pay you Friday." A regular, a fleet account, a family friend. Without a list, small balances are forgotten, and some are never collected.

The fix

- No car leaves without payment, or an account arrangement that is written down.
- Keep one list of everyone who owes you and look at it every Monday.
- Call at 7 days and again at 30. Most people pay when they're simply reminded.

> **In XSite Auto:** money owing to you shows on the Today screen and on each customer, so nothing is forgotten.

8 A cash drawer that never quite adds up

When the drawer is a few dollars off most nights, nobody knows if it's a counting error or a real problem, and the books get adjusted to match.

The fix

- Count the drawer at the same time every day and record totals by payment type: cash, debit and credit, e-transfer and cheque.
- Write down the difference instead of fixing it. Over a month, the pattern tells you what's happening.
- One person is responsible for the drawer each day.

> **In XSite Auto:** daily totals by payment type, a drawer count at close, and an export for QuickBooks.

9 Empty hours one day, overbooked the next

Booking by time slot alone ignores how long the work takes and who is on shift. The result is idle technicians on Tuesday and customers waiting on Thursday.

The fix

- Book against technician hours. Know how many hours each tech has available and how many are already sold.
- Keep a little room each day for walk-ins and diagnosis that turns into work.
- When a gap opens, fill it from your list of declined work (see the next leak).

> **In XSite Auto:** the day schedule shows booked hours against available hours for each technician.

10 Recommended work that never comes back

Every shop recommends work that the customer declines today: brakes at 4 mm, a weeping gasket, tires that will need replacing before winter. Most shops never follow up, and that work goes elsewhere.

The fix

- Write every declined recommendation on the repair order with a price.
- Call or email about it in two to four weeks, and bring it up again at the next visit.
- Use the list to fill quiet days.

Quick check: how many of these leak in your shop?

Score yourself one point for each leak you recognized. Three or more is normal for a busy small shop, and it's also where the easiest money is. Start with the leak that made you wince.

PART 2

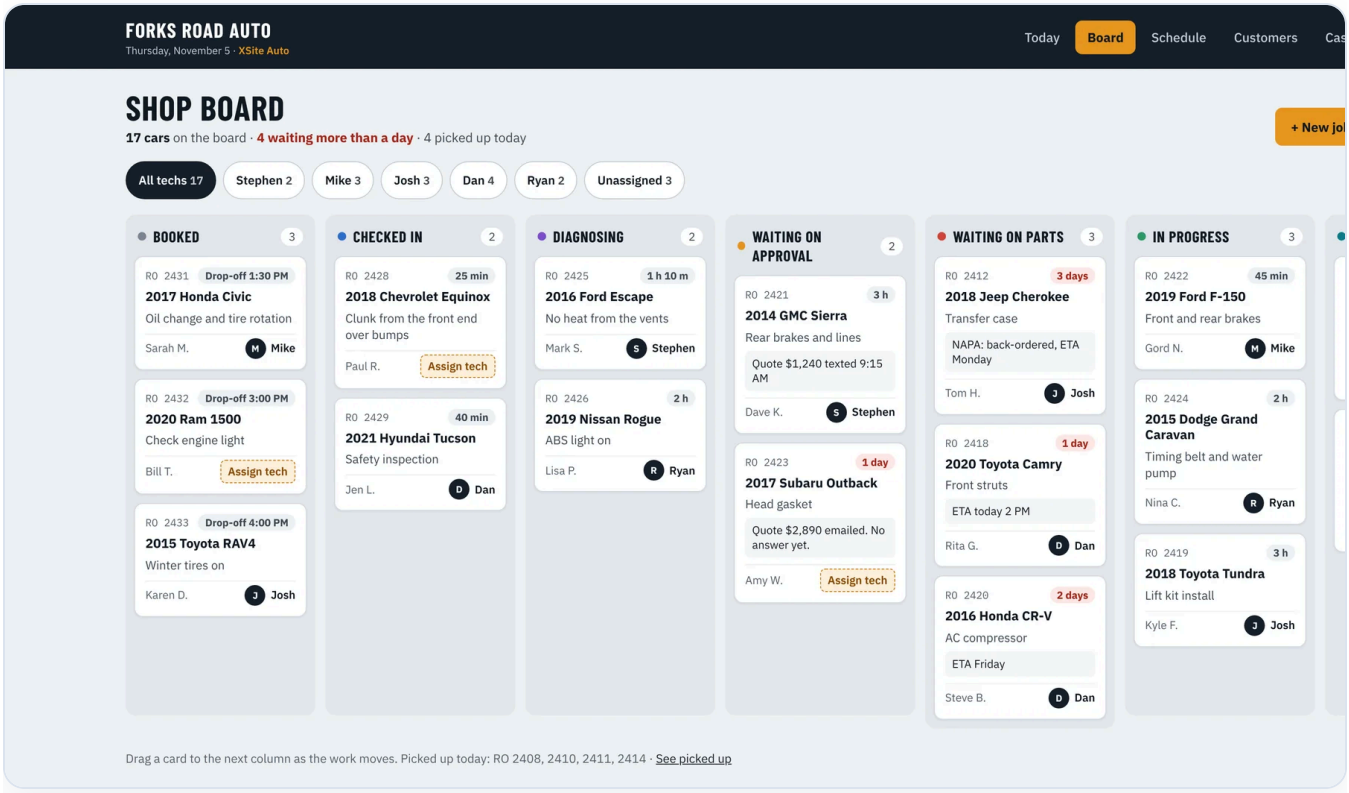
Running the day, from first call to close

Calm shops aren't less busy. They run the same routine every day, so nobody has to remember where things stand. Here is a routine that works for shops with one to ten technicians.

BEFORE OPENING

Fifteen minutes with the board

- Look at every car on today's schedule and who is working on it.
- Check that parts for the first jobs have arrived.
- Know which cars are carried over from yesterday and what each is waiting on.



The shop board in XSite Auto: every car in one column by stage, from booked to in progress.

EVERY BOOKING

Take the same details every time

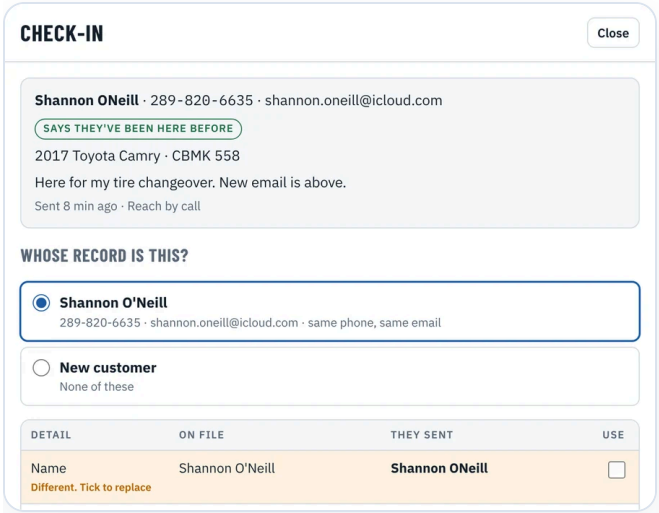
- Name, a phone number that takes texts, and an email.
- Year, make and model, and the concern in the customer's own words.
- When they can bring it in, and whether they're waiting or dropping it off.

Whether a booking comes by phone, walk-in or online, the same details make every later step faster.

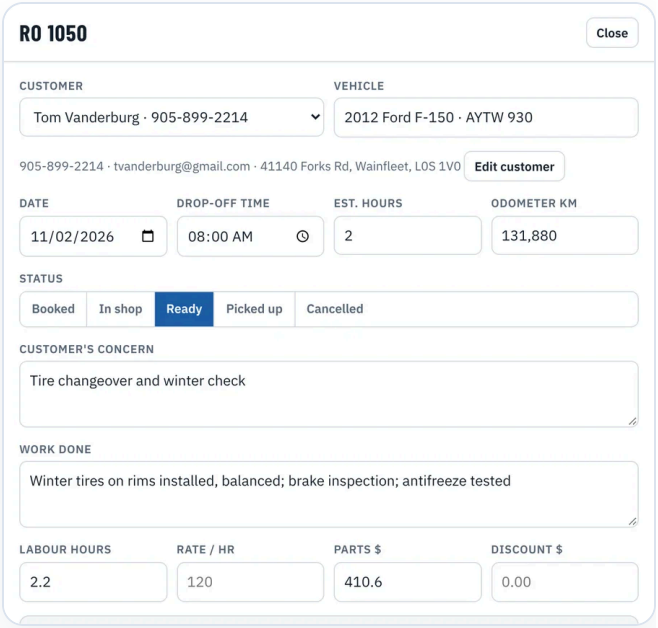
AT THE COUNTER

A two-minute check-in

- Confirm contact details and mileage, and repeat the concern back to the customer.
- Ask how they want to be contacted, and the amount you can go ahead on without calling.
- Tag the keys and put the car on the board.



Walk-ins scan a QR code at the counter and fill in their own details.



One repair order with the concern, work done, labour and parts.

DIAGNOSIS

Find it, price it, sort it

- Time-box the diagnosis and record what was found, with a photo when it helps.
- Build the quote with parts, labour and tax before calling the customer.
- Sort recommendations into three groups: safety and needed now, needed soon, and can wait.

APPROVAL

Get a clear yes or no

- Call first, then send the quote in writing.
- Record the approval, the amount and the time. Write down anything declined, with its price.

PARTS

Track what you're waiting for

- Write the parts ETA on the job and tell the customer the same day.
- If a car will sit overnight, move it off the hoist so the bay keeps earning.

IN THE BAY

One car at a time, status kept current

- Each technician has one active job. When it changes stage, move it on the board.
- Finish with the road test and the final check list from Part 1.

PICKUP

Ready before they walk in

- Call the customer as soon as the car is ready, with the total.
- Have the invoice printed or sent before they arrive. Walk through the work done and anything recommended for next time.
- Ask happy customers for a review while they're standing at the counter (more in Part 3).

PAYMENT

Paid, or written down

- Take payment before the keys go back. If it's going on account, write it down with a due date.

The ten-minute close

- Count the drawer and record totals by payment type.
- Read through today's repair orders for work that wasn't billed.
- Check who still owes you, and who needs a call tomorrow.
- Look at tomorrow's board: first jobs, technicians on shift and parts due.
- Bring the day into QuickBooks, daily or at least weekly, so the books never pile up.

PART 3

Keeping the schedule full

Most new customers find a shop the same way: they search on their phone, look at the reviews, and book the shop that makes it easiest. The shops that win aren't always the best technicians. They're the easiest to find, trust and book.

1. Own your Google Business Profile

For most small shops, this free listing brings in more new customers than their website does.

- Claim it, and make sure your hours, phone number, address and services are right, including holiday hours.
- Add real photos of your shop, your bays and your team. Update them a few times a year.
- Add a booking link so people can book straight from the listing.

2. Ask for reviews, every day

- The best time to ask is at pickup, when the customer is happy and the car is fixed. Ask in person, then send the link.
- Make it easy: a short link or a QR code at the counter that goes straight to your review page.
- Reply to every review, good and bad. A calm, polite reply to a bad review often wins more trust than the review loses.

3. Let customers book any time

Many people decide to book their car in at night, after work, when you're closed. If the only way to book is to call during the day, some of them never do.

- Put a "Book online" button on your website, your Google profile and your Facebook page, and in your email signature.
- Print a QR code for the counter and the window.
- Decide which services can be booked online and how many per day, so you stay in control.

4. Make your website do one job well

Your website doesn't need to be fancy. On a phone, a customer should be able to do three things within five seconds: tap to call, see your hours and location, and book.

- List your services in plain words, the way customers search for them, such as "brake repair" or "check engine light".
- Keep a notice banner for holidays, closures and seasonal offers, and keep it up to date.

5. Cut no-shows with a reminder

- Contact every customer the day before their appointment, by text or a quick call, and ask them to confirm.
- When someone can't make it, rebook them on the spot and offer their slot to someone waiting.

6. Bring customers back

Selling more work to customers who already trust you costs far less than finding new ones.

- Follow up on declined work from Part 1. It's the warmest list you have.
- Send seasonal reminders: winter tires, air conditioning checks, pre-trip inspections.
- Thank customers after a big job. A short note or email a few days later is remembered.

7. Be the shop local businesses call

Contractors, landscapers and delivery businesses have vehicles that can't sit. Offer them a simple account and priority booking, and get to know the tow operators and tire shops nearby. They send work to shops they trust.

LAST

Your first 30 days

Don't try to do it all at once. Work through one week at a time and tick things off as you go.

Week 1: See where it leaks

- [ ] Log every missed call for the week.
- [ ] Write every task on the repair order, even the free ones.
- [ ] Make one list of everyone who owes you money.
- [ ] Count the drawer at the same time every day and write down the difference.

Week 2: Tighten the counter

- [ ] Use the same check-in questions with every customer, including how they want to be contacted.
- [ ] Post your diagnostic fee and say it on the phone.
- [ ] Make one person responsible for approvals, checking twice a day.
- [ ] Start the ten-minute close.

Week 3: Get found and booked

- [ ] Update your Google Business Profile: hours, photos, services and a booking link.
- [ ] Put a review QR code at the counter and ask every happy customer.
- [ ] Give customers a way to book online, and change your voicemail to point to it.

Week 4: Bring the work back

- [ ] Call everyone on your declined-work list from the past three months.
- [ ] Contact every customer the day before their appointment.
- [ ] Look at your first month's notes. Pick the next leak to plug.

WHERE XSITE AUTO FITS

The routine, without the paperwork

Everything in this playbook works on paper. XSite Auto was built so that the habits happen on their own, in one place, for shops with ten technicians or fewer.

IN THIS PLAYBOOK	IN XSITE AUTO
Missed calls, booking any time	Online booking from your website, Google profile or a QR code. Requests land on your schedule.
A two-minute check-in	Walk-ins scan a QR code at the counter and fill in their own details and vehicle.
Fifteen minutes with the board	A live shop board with every car by stage: booked, checked in, diagnosing, waiting on approval, waiting on parts, in progress.
Empty hours and overbooked days	A day schedule with one column per technician, showing hours booked against hours available.
Labour on the invoice	Repair orders with the concern, work done, labour and parts on one screen.
Balances that slip through	Money owing shown on the Today screen and on every customer.
The ten-minute close	Daily totals by payment type, a drawer count at close and an export for QuickBooks.
A website that does one job well	A fast shop website with booking built in, and a notice banner, hours and prices you can change yourself.
Starting with your real data	Your QuickBooks customers and balances imported in minutes.

Try it in your shop, free for 14 days

Built alongside a working Niagara repair shop run by a former Toyota master technician, with real people in Niagara who pick up the phone.

$139 CAD a month, plus tax after a free 14-day trial, with no credit card needed and no contract. Done-for-you setup is optional ($695 CAD, one time).

Start a free trial | **Book a 15-minute demo**

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